



▲ THE QUEEN'S MEGARON (SUITE) AT THE PALACE OF KING MINOS

Europe

Palace of King Minos

Location Crete, Greece

From about 2800 BCE, the first distinctively Greek culture, the Minoan, flourished on the island of Crete. During its heyday, it was a vibrant, organized society. It was epitomized by the palace of the mythical King Minos at Knossos, built perhaps after 2000 BCE—the high point of the Minoan civilization. What remains is largely a reconstruction, built by British archaeologist Arthur Evans in the 1920s. The mostly two-story complex, built around a central courtyard, sprawls over 21,500 square ft (2,000 square m) and has more than 1,300 rooms—some ceremonial, most more utilitarian. The Minoan taste for vivid colors is evident in the reconstructed frescoes, teeming with animal life.

Capitoline Temple of Jupiter

Location Rome, Italy

The Capitoline Temple of Jupiter, dedicated in 509 BCE, at the very start of the Republican era, was the

first of the great temples of Rome. It was built on an imposing stone podium 203 ft (62 m) long; 174 ft (53 m) wide; and, importantly, 13 ft (4 m) high, although only parts of this structure have survived. The temple represented a transplanted Greek tradition filtered through Etruscan practices, evident above all in its use of a high base and a deep and commanding porch, with three rows of six columns. Unlike later, more characteristic Roman temples, the columns continued along the side walls. The building was rebuilt with progressively more sumptuous materials several times, notably in 83 BCE. The original consisted mostly of wood.

Statue of Zeus

Location Olympia, Greece

The Statue of Zeus, which stood in the Temple of Zeus, built in the 5th century BCE at Olympia, was one of the Seven Wonders of the World. Completed around 435 BCE, it was the work of Phidias, the most celebrated of all ancient Greek sculptors. No trace of the statue remains today, and there are no visual representations other than those on a few Roman coins. Even the circumstances of its loss are unknown. However, there are descriptions by contemporary writers that report a seated figure of

massive size—43 ft (13 m) tall—and extraordinary opulence, constructed of ivory, gold, ebony, and glass, with jewels studding Zeus's robes and his immense throne. In one hand, he clasped a staff; in the other, he held a gold-and-ivory figure of Nike, the Greek goddess of victory.

Erechtheion

Location Athens, Greece

Built in 421–405 BCE, the little temple of the Erechtheion is on the Acropolis, to the north of the Parthenon (see pp.98–99). It was extensively damaged during its life, and what little remains is the result of rebuilding. It is unusual in that its plan is asymmetrical, with three separate porticos; however, this reflects its role as a shrine to three objects of devotion, including King Erechtheus of the Archaic Greek era, after whom the temple is named. Its most famous features are the caryatids that support the south porch. These six slim and precisely carved female figures act as columns, their robes echoing the fluting of the slender shafts of the Ionic columns on the other two porticos. All six are reconstructions.

Theatre of Epidaurus

Location Epidaurus, Greece

By the time the open-air Theatre of Epidaurus was built in the mid-4th century BCE, the tradition of Greek drama pioneered in Athens in the 5th century had ended. Nevertheless, the building is not just the most complete example of an ancient Greek theater; it is also remarkable for its simplicity, size, and functionality. For example, its acoustics are thought to be near perfect. Originally, it had three elements: the immense semicircular marble auditorium; the circular stage, or orchestra, at its foot; and behind that a stage building, or skene. Only the first two survive. The auditorium, which seats more than 13,000 in 55 rows,

has a diameter of 387 ft (118 m) and the orchestra has a diameter of 67 ft (20.5 m). It remains in regular use.

The Colossus of Rhodes

Location Rhodes, Greece

The Colossus of Rhodes, representing the Sun god Helios, was one of the Seven Wonders of

